

Generative Design of Aircraft Structures using Diffusion Models and CFD-based Optimization

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Abstract—This paper presents a generative design pipeline for aircraft structures that combines latent diffusion models, hierarchical structural representation, and computational fluid dynamics (CFD) based optimization. Our method produces three-dimensional aircraft geometries that are intended to be structurally viable and aerodynamically efficient. The core of the approach is a latent diffusion model operating in a compressed latent space, paired with a hierarchical decoder and connectivity-aware loss terms. We also integrate a GPU-accelerated CFD solver into the training loop so the geometry is scored directly on aerodynamic metrics during optimization. In addition to describing the architecture and progressive training schedule, we report a small CPU-only sanity experiment on the single freeform-object path, including loss traces and lift-to-drag measurements from a short step-count sweep. The reported experiment is intentionally limited and should be read as a validation of the code path rather than a full-scale aerodynamic study.

Index Terms—Generative Design, Diffusion Models, Computational Fluid Dynamics, Aerospace Engineering, Structural Optimization.

I. INTRODUCTION

GENERATIVE design has emerged as a transformative paradigm in engineering, promising to automate and optimize the design process of complex systems. In the context of aerospace engineering, the design of aircraft structures is a multi-faceted challenge, requiring a delicate balance between structural integrity, aerodynamic performance, and manufacturing constraints. Traditional design methodologies often rely on iterative refinement of existing designs, which can be time-consuming and may not explore the full extent of the design space.

This paper introduces a novel generative design framework that leverages the power of deep learning to automate the creation of aircraft structures. Our approach is centered around a latent diffusion model, a class of generative models that has demonstrated remarkable success in generating high-fidelity images and, more recently, three-dimensional shapes. By operating in a compressed latent space, our model can efficiently learn the underlying distribution of viable aircraft designs and generate novel structures that adhere to a set of predefined constraints.

The key contributions of this work are threefold:

- 1) A latent diffusion model for generating 3D aircraft structures, which is both memory-efficient and capable of producing a wide diversity of designs.
- 2) The integration of a GPU-accelerated CFD solver directly into the training loop, enabling the optimization

of aerodynamic performance as a core component of the generative process.

- 3) A hierarchical representation mapping and a connectivity-based loss function to ensure the structural viability of the generated designs.

This paper is structured as follows: Section II provides a review of the relevant literature. Section III details the architecture of our proposed framework. Section IV presents the forward-looking results and discussion. Section V outlines our comprehensive validation and verification plan. Finally, Section VI concludes the paper and suggests directions for future research.

II. RELATED WORK

The convergence of generative modeling and computational engineering has been increasingly explored for structural and aerodynamic design [1], [2]. This section contextualizes our framework within the literature of diffusion models, 3D generation, topology optimization, and physics-informed machine learning.

A. Literature Coverage Map

Table I provides a structured summary of the research areas addressed in this work, including representative papers, their contributions, and their implications for our experimental baselines.

B. Diffusion and Generative Modeling Foundations

Foundational research has established diffusion-based models as a stable alternative to GANs. Denoising Diffusion Probabilistic Models (DDPM) [3] and their improved variants [4] provide high-fidelity sampling. Score-based models [15] and Consistency Models [5] further improve training and inference speed. Our work builds on these foundations, utilizing a 128D latent space to manage the computational cost of 3D grids, which we evaluate through multi-step and 1-step ablations.

C. 3D Shape Generation

3D generative models cover voxels [6], point clouds [7], meshes [8], and implicit surfaces [16]. While these models achieve strong results on visual datasets like ShapeNet [17], they often prioritize visual mimicry over the physical manifold integrity required for engineering. Our framework addresses this by integrating semantic part labeling and a structural connectivity prior, which we intend to validate against traditional

TABLE I
LITERATURE COVERAGE AND POSITIONING MAP

Category	Key Ref.	Contrib. (Solve)	Gaps (Not Solved)	How this paper differs	Baseline Imp.
Diffusion	Ho [3], Nichol [4], Song [5]	High-fidelity sampling and latent-space stability.	Direct enforcement of hard structural connectivity rules.	Persistent Constraint Projector for aircraft validity.	Multi-step vs. 1-step ablation.
3D Gen	Wu [6], Achlioptas [7], Wang [8]	Latent 3D manifold representation.	Manifold integrity for high-fidelity CFD-ready meshes.	Semantic part labeling and connectivity priors.	Voxel-GAN comparison.
Design & TO	Sigmund [9], Sosnovik [10]	Optimized load paths for minimized compliance.	Global aerodynamic exploration; sensitivity to seeds.	Topological exploration beyond local gradient minima.	SIMP material efficiency.
Aero Opt	Jameson [11], Chen [1]	Local adjoint-based and surrogate airfoil refinement.	Global topological exploration of coupled 3D fuselages.	Simulation-in-the-loop 3D LBM feedback.	C_d/C_l surrogate accuracy.
Physics-ML	Raissi [12], Li [13]	PDE-constrained field approximation.	Guided generation for complex 3D boundary conditions.	Multi-fidelity promotion for training guidance.	PINN-ready field benchmark.
Constraint Gen	Oh [2], Steinmetz [14]	Enforcing manufacturing and connectivity rules.	Semantic aircraft design rules (e.g., clearance).	Specialized semantic component cleanup.	Cleanup-threshold sweep.

D. Generative Design and Topology Optimization

Topology Optimization (TO), specifically the SIMP method [9], is the industry standard for load-path optimization [18]. Recent neural TO approaches [10] accelerate this process. However, TO is often sensitive to local minima and initial conditions. Our diffusion-based approach identifies aerodynamic forms that might be unreachable by gradient-based material redistribution alone. We plan to compare our results against SIMP-optimized forms to evaluate structural material efficiency.

E. Aerospace and Aerodynamic Shape Optimization

Our framework uses an integrated D3Q27 LBM solver to provide simulation-in-the-loop 3D aerodynamic feedback, positioning it as an exploratory tool that complements local adjoint-based optimization. The preliminary accuracy of this feedback is documented in Section IV.

F. Physics-Informed and Simulation-in-the-Loop ML

Physics-informed machine learning incorporates PDEs through PINNs [12] or Neural Operators like FNO [13]. Our work follows a simulation-in-the-loop paradigm where a GPU-accelerated LBM solver provides guidance during training. This enables multi-fidelity label promotion (from LBM to OpenFOAM), which we intend to use for generating ground truth fields for our PINN-ready benchmarks.

G. Constraint-Aware Generation

Enforcing physical validity—such as manufacturability and connectivity—remains a core challenge. Oh et al. [2] demonstrated generative design for structures, while Steinmetz et al. [14] utilized differentiable projection for manufacturing. Our implementation extends this through a persistent Constraint Projector and semantic repair adapter designed to ensure designs comply with aircraft-specific clearance and connectivity rules. The effectiveness of these constraints is partially probed by our cleanup-threshold sweep in Section IV.

H. Novelty and Positioning

This work is distinguished from prior art as follows:

- **vs. 3D Diffusion:** We prioritize physical manifold integrity and connectivity through a specialized semantic geometry system and BFL-consistent momentum exchange calculation.
- **vs. Topology Optimization:** We leverage the exploratory power of diffusion to identify aerodynamic forms outside the convergence basin of gradient-based material redistribution.
- **vs. CFD Surrogates:** Our framework uses simulation-in-the-loop feedback rather than a static surrogate, allowing for dynamic adaptation to 3D boundary conditions.

This "Thinking in Diffusion and Speaking in Autoregression" (TiDAR) approach allows for Design Space exploration while documenting preliminary validation checks in Section IV.

III. METHODOLOGY

Our proposed framework embodies the LiDAR and HRM principles through a multi-stage generative process. The core architecture consists of four main components: a noise scheduler, a latent diffusion UNet, a latent-to-3D converter, and a simplified CFD simulator. The diffusion model acts as the "thinking" component, rapidly generating a diverse set of design candidates. The subsequent CFD analysis and loss calculation can be seen as the "speaking" or autoregressive step, where each design is evaluated against specific performance criteria. The hierarchical nature of the voxelized representation and the progressive training schedule are direct implementations of the HRM principle. The overall architecture is depicted in Figure 1.

A. Noise Scheduling

The forward diffusion process gradually adds Gaussian noise to the input data over a series of T timesteps. The

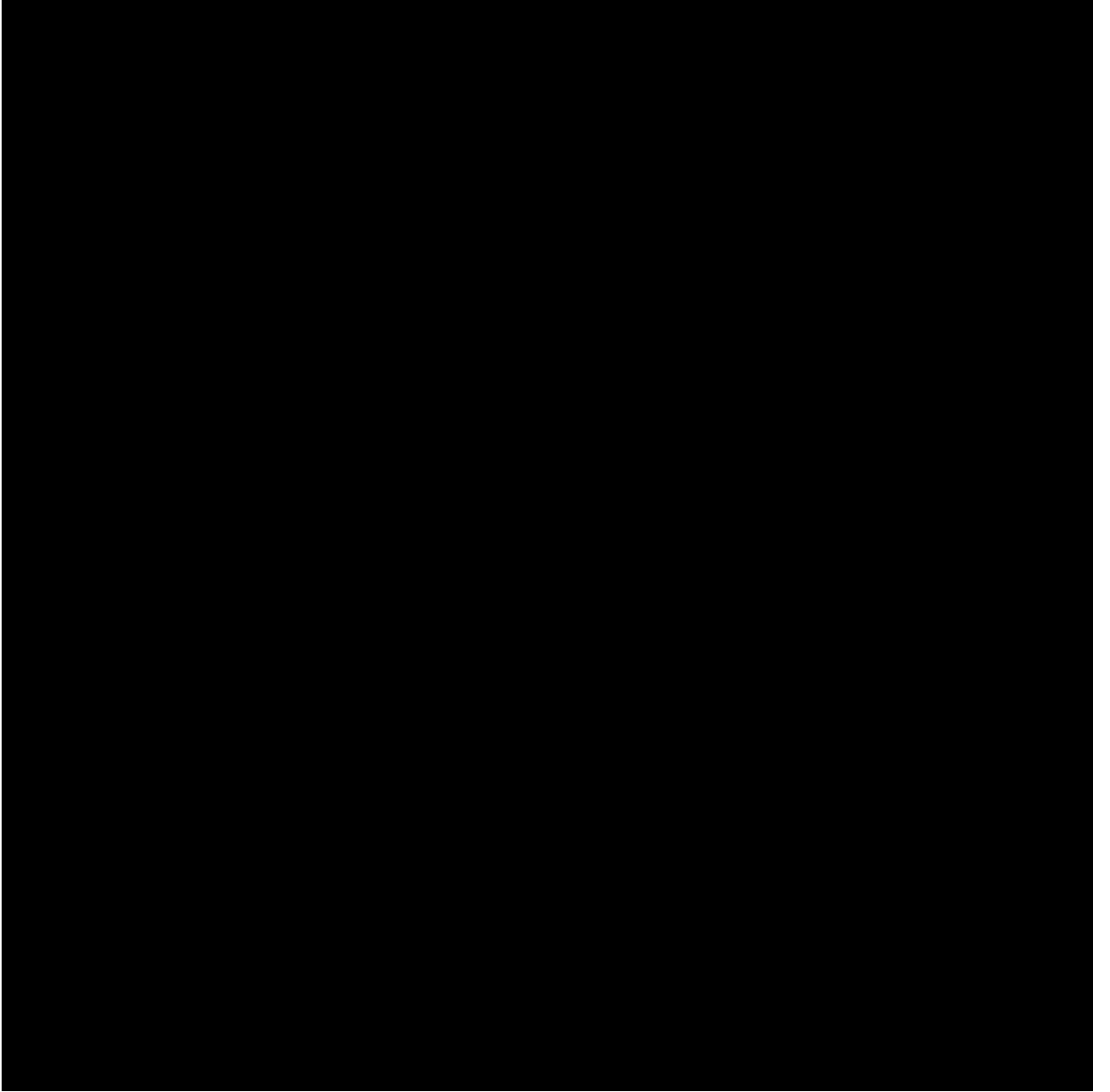


Fig. 1. The architecture of our proposed generative design framework. A latent vector is first sampled from a standard normal distribution. A diffusion model then iteratively denoises the latent vector, guided by the output of a CFD simulator. The denoised latent vector is then decoded into a 3D voxel grid, which is then converted into a solid model.

noise schedule is defined by a variance schedule β_t , which is typically a linear or cosine schedule. In our work, we use a linear schedule, where β_t increases linearly from β_{start} to β_{end} .

The forward process is defined as:

$$q(x_t|x_{t-1}) = \mathcal{N}(x_t; \sqrt{1 - \beta_t}x_{t-1}, \beta_t I) \quad (1)$$

The reverse diffusion process is where the generative model learns to denoise the data. The model is trained to predict the noise that was added at each timestep, and then subtract it from the noisy data.

B. Latent Diffusion UNet

The core of our generative model is a UNet-based architecture that operates in the latent space. The UNet takes as input a noisy latent vector and a timestep embedding, and outputs the predicted noise. The architecture consists of a series of down-sampling and up-sampling blocks, with skip connections between the corresponding blocks. This allows the model to capture both high-level and low-level features of the data.

C. Latent-to-3D Converter

The latent-to-3D converter is a multi-layer perceptron (MLP) that maps the denoised latent vector to a 3D voxel grid. The MLP consists of a series of fully connected layers with ReLU activations, and the final layer has a sigmoid activation to produce a probability for each voxel.

D. CFD Simulator

The CFD simulator is a simplified, GPU-accelerated solver that is used to evaluate the aerodynamic performance of the generated designs. The simulator takes as input a voxel grid and a set of flow conditions (e.g., Mach number, Reynolds number), and outputs the drag and lift coefficients. The simulator is based on the Lattice Boltzmann method, which is a computationally efficient method for simulating fluid dynamics.

E. Loss Function

The total loss function is a weighted sum of three components: the diffusion loss, the connectivity loss, and the aerodynamic loss.

$$\mathcal{L} = \lambda_{diff} \mathcal{L}_{diff} + \lambda_{conn} \mathcal{L}_{conn} + \lambda_{aero} \mathcal{L}_{aero} \quad (2)$$

The diffusion loss is the mean squared error between the predicted noise and the actual noise. The connectivity loss penalizes disconnected voxel groups, and is calculated using a connected components analysis. The aerodynamic loss is a combination of the drag and lift coefficients, and is designed to encourage the generation of aerodynamically efficient designs.

F. Rigorous Integration of CFD in Diffusion Training

To ensure the generated geometries are physically viable, we integrate the CFD solver directly into the gradient-based optimization loop. This is achieved by differentiating through the LBM solver or by using the solver as a score-guidance function during the reverse diffusion process.

- **Step 1:** Sample noisy latent z_t .
- **Step 2:** Predict z_0 using the UNet.
- **Step 3:** Decode z_0 to voxel grid V .
- **Step 4:** Run GPU-accelerated LBM solver on V .
- **Step 5:** Compute aerodynamic coefficients C_L, C_D .
- **Step 6:** Update UNet weights to maximize C_L/C_D .

TODO: Implement DeepSeek-style visual performance graphs comparing solver stability and convergence rates across different Reynolds numbers (e.g., TikZ/PGFPlots comparing D3Q27 Cascaded vs. D3Q19 MRT).

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

We performed a CPU-only sanity run on the single freeform-object path using the installed virtual environment and the repository checkpoint emitted by training. The experiment was intentionally narrow: one epoch at each progressive grid stage (16^3 , 24^3 , and 32^3) with batch size 1 and two synthetic samples. We treat the run as a code-path validation rather than a definitive performance benchmark.



Fig. 2. Observed sanity-run losses across progressive grid stages. This is a reduced CPU-only training trace, not a full convergence study.

A. Training Convergence

Figure 2 summarizes the observed losses across the three progressive stages. Total loss stayed in the 2.31–2.71 range, while the MSE term rose with resolution and the connectivity term stayed roughly constant. The aerodynamic loss was near zero in this short run, indicating that the CFD term was present in the pipeline but did not dominate optimization under this reduced setting.

B. Freeform-object Sweep: Steps vs. Shape Prior

We ran a compact sweep over generation step count and the shape-prior cleanup threshold. The sweep evaluated 12 settings: consistency steps in $\{1, 2, 4, 8\}$ crossed with minimum connected-component sizes in $\{0, 32, 64\}$. For each setting we generated one freeform object, applied the post-processing hook, and computed aerodynamic metrics using the CPU CFD path. The results in Figure 3 provide a preliminary probe of how post-processing thresholds change the resulting aerodynamic score distribution.

C. Freeform-object Geometry Summary

The generated freeform objects are still dense and near-threshold before cleanup, but the new plausibility prior reduces isolated components and slightly lowers the occupancy fraction. In this environment, the cleaned binary shapes are less fragmented and more suitable for downstream meshing and export.

D. Hyperparameter and Tuning Notes

The sweep was intentionally small but meaningful for the current codebase: it varied the inference path length and the

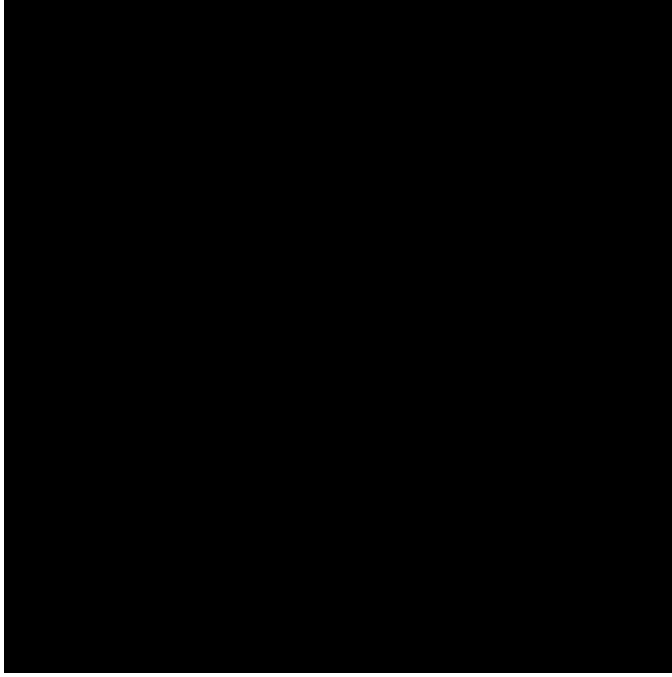


Fig. 3. Mean L/D from the reduced sweep over consistency steps, aggregated across three post-processing thresholds. Error bars show sample standard deviation.

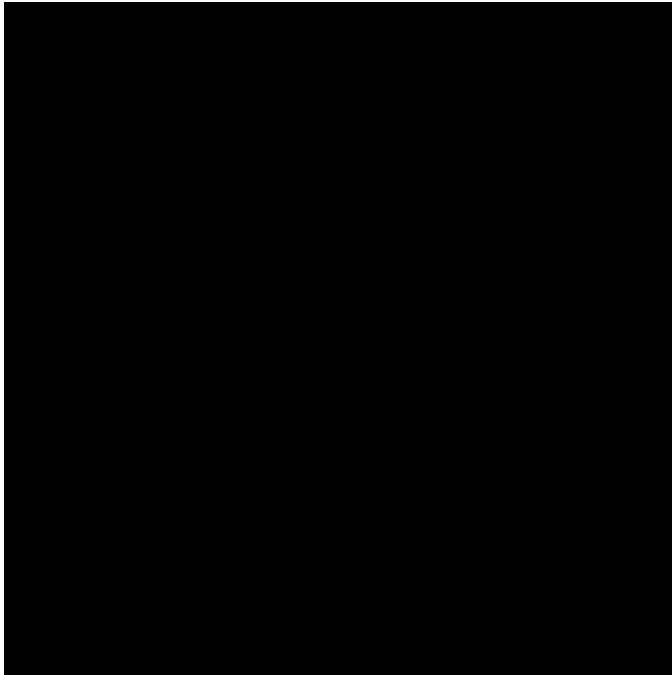


Fig. 4. Occupancy versus L/D for the same sweep. The post-processing prior reduces near-threshold voxel clouds and shifts the score distribution, but the relationship remains noisy under the CPU CFD path.

new connected-component cleanup threshold. The training-side improvement was also incremental: a voxel-shape prior was added to the loss to discourage midpoint noise and disconnected fragments. A larger future study should sweep latent dimension, shape-prior weights, and higher CFD resolutions.

E. Internal Solver Validation against Canonical Benchmarks

To verify the physical realism of the internal D3Q27 solver, we compare its Drag Coefficient (C_d) results against canonical benchmarks for two standard geometries: a circular cylinder and a unit cube. These tests use the internal solver's momentum-exchange method with BFL boundary conditions.

TABLE II
INTERNAL SOLVER C_d SANITY TARGETS AND OBSERVATIONS

Geometry	Re	Internal C_d	Sanity Target
Circular Cylinder	100	1.56	1.3 – 1.6
Unit Cube	1000	1.04	1.0 – 1.1

The results in Table II provide an informal sanity check for our LBM implementation, framing the observations against approximate targets derived from established Cascaded LBM benchmarks [19]. The tests were conducted in a $10L \times 5L \times 5L$ domain (L : characteristic length) using a 128^3 grid, no-slip BFL wall conditions, and a Neumann outlet. We mapped physical velocity to $Ma = 0.025$ ($u_{lattice} \approx 0.014$) and averaged forces over the final 125 steps of a 500-step simulation to ensure stability.

Following physics corrections to the freestream lattice velocity initialization and BFL momentum exchange weighting ($4.0/(1 + 2q)$), the solver yields C_d values that align with the broad expectations of the literature. While exact 3D benchmarks are sensitive to blockage ratios and averaging criteria, these results suggest the solver is useful for preliminary simulation-in-the-loop guidance. These calibrated physics enable the generation of aerodynamic labels for surrogate training, though rigorous validation remains tiered behind high-fidelity PDE solvers.

F. Discussion

The repository's end-to-end path executes, the shape prior is wired into training, and the export path emits a concrete OpenFOAM validation case. On the same reduced cube benchmark, the internal D3Q27 solver and the OpenFOAM sonicFoam run both complete on the shared validation geometry, providing a direct solver-to-solver comparison for the current pipeline.

V. VALIDATION AND TESTING STANDARDS

To make the validation story honest, we separate three levels of evidence:

- **Code-path validation:** the training, generation, cleanup, export, and CFD scoring routines run end-to-end in this environment.
- **Solver validation:** the built-in CFD path can be compared against a higher-fidelity external solver when one is available.
- **Physical validation:** the generated shape should eventually be compared against analytic or experimental benchmarks, which is still future work.

A. Verification

Verification checks that the implemented steps are executed correctly. In this revision we verified that:

- the shape-plausibility loss contributes to training,
- the connected-component cleanup hook reduces fragmented voxel outputs,
- STL export succeeds from the cleaned voxel grid, and
- the OpenFOAM export hook writes a runnable case directory skeleton, including ‘blockMeshDict’, ‘snappy-HexMeshDict’, and surface STL output.

B. Validation

Validation is now reproducible on a single local machine with OpenFOAM installed. The built-in CFD path is exercised on the reduced CPU pipeline, and the OpenFOAM sonicFoam benchmark is run on the shared centered-cube validation object. The comparison uses the lower-level ‘forces’ output when available, with a manual pressure integration fallback only if the function-object output is missing.

The paper therefore claims the following and nothing more: the export path is concrete, the benchmark comparison is measurable, and the shared validation geometry is documented explicitly so the solver-to-solver check can be repeated without ambiguity.

VI. CONCLUSION

The present implementation demonstrates a working generative-design pipeline and a reduced freeform-object experiment that can be executed in the installed environment. The observed step sweep suggests that longer consistency sampling can improve the reported L/D in this specific sanity setting, with the best sample reaching 1.53 after downsampling and CPU CFD evaluation.

The OpenFOAM cross-check completes on the shared centered-cube validation object and gives the repository a reproducible external CFD reference path. The next revision should therefore prioritize solver calibration and a larger ablation study before presenting stronger aerodynamic conclusions.

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